



RANJAN RAHII

BIHAR GOT 51 NEW TRAINS DURING LALU'S TENURE AS RAILWAY MINISTER

suspended animation.

It all begun amid speculation that Banerjee was willing to transfer some of these projects to West Bengal even though she found an ally in Bihar in the form of Chief Minister Nitish Kumar. Banerjee's decision of bringing out a White Paper on the performance of the Railways in the last five years came immediately after Kumar had appealed to her to probe Lalu's claims of earning a cash surplus of Rs 90,000 crore. The railway minister later pegged the cash

surplus at around Rs 8,000 crore which prompted Kumar to seek an apology from Lalu for jugglery of figures. Banerjee and Kumar's bonhomie was visible when the latter gave a thumbs up to the "balanced railway budget" while all state leaders, including Deputy Chief Minister Sushil Kumar Modi, berated it for "ignoring Bihar".

Besides anti-Lalu politics, Kumar has some other reasons to hail the budget. Banerjee has reportedly allocated a sizeable amount in the current

fiscal for the upcoming coach maintenance workshop at Harnaut in Kumar's home district Nalanda. In fact, the factory, which remained neglected during Lalu's tenure, was conceptualised and launched in 2003 by Kumar when he happened to be the railway minister. Now it will perhaps be the first of the ongoing projects in Bihar to be completed. The cost of the project has since then been revised from Rs 98 crore to Rs 224.51 crore. On the other hand, the Chapra wheel factory launched by Lalu has got lesser allocation this fiscal than what is required to complete it this year as per the deadline.

For over a decade, Bihar has been a pampered state when it comes to railway projects. Since 1995, barring a brief period between 2000 and 2001 when Banerjee was at the helm, the reins of the ministry have been with political heavyweights from Bihar. The Railways was a big gravy train for these politicians who strengthened their political fortunes in Bihar through largesse in the form of new trains, factories, extension of lines, gauge conversion and so on. In 1996, Ram Vilas Paswan initiated the creation of several additional zones, including one that was headquartered in Hajipur, his constituency. Kumar held the portfolio in 2003 and he too introduced many new trains to and through Bihar, besides formally completing the bifurcation of the Eastern Railway. And under Lalu, Bihar got 51 new trains.

The 15th Lok Sabha, however, threw up a surprise for Bihar as there is no representation from the state in the Union Council of Ministers, perhaps for the first time. "Being unrepresented means nothing, as even the Central ministers from Bihar during the previous regime did nothing for the state. The Centre is once again meting out stepmotherly treatment to Bihar," says Modi.

Whether the previous ministers from the state made any contribution to Bihar's growth or not is debatable, but one thing is certain: Lalu's railway turnaround story did not create the same magic among the target beneficiaries that it did with management schools and gurus. ■



KM KISHAN

Project

Coach maintenance workshop at Harnaut in Nalanda, Nitish Kumar's home district

STATUS

May become the first of the ongoing railway projects in Bihar to be completed, thanks to Mamata Banerjee's handsome budget allocation

Project

Concrete sleeper factories at Madhepura

STATUS

Plant ready but no production being done

Project

New railway divisions in Bhagalpur and Thawe

STATUS

Yet to take formal shape

STATUS

Work in progress but very unlikely to meet the 18-month deadline set by Lalu in July last year